

Proposal for the Enhancement of Development Studies at Valley View University Through Academic Collaboration With UDS/UBIDS

The field of Development Studies continues to evolve globally as nations seek innovative and interdisciplinary approaches to solving socio-economic, environmental, governance, and rural development challenges. In Ghana, one institution that historically distinguished itself in this area is the former Faculty of Integrated Development Studies (FIDS) at the Wa Campus of the University for Development Studies, now known as University of Business and Integrated Development Studies (UBIDS).

As an alumnus of both Valley View University and the former Faculty of Integrated Development Studies at UDS Wa Campus, I strongly believe that the Faculty of Development Studies at Valley View University can benefit significantly from studying and collaborating with the academic model developed by UDS during the 2008/2009 academic period.

What made the IDS programme at UDS particularly unique was its strong interdisciplinary structure. Instead of limiting students to a narrow social science education, the Faculty integrated economics, entrepreneurship, environmental science, planning, governance, communication, and rural development into one comprehensive development-oriented framework.

The programme operated through five major departments, each contributing a critical dimension to development education.

1. Department of Economics & Entrepreneurship Development

The Department of Economics & Entrepreneurship Development focused on equipping students with practical economic and business-oriented skills necessary for poverty reduction, local economic growth, entrepreneurship, and sustainable development.

The department exposed students to:

- Development Economics
- Microeconomics and Macroeconomics
- Entrepreneurship Development
- Agricultural Economics
- Cooperative Development

- Project Appraisal
- Business Management
- Financial Management
- Investment Analysis
- Rural Enterprise Development

This department was highly practical and aimed at helping students understand how economic systems affect communities, especially rural populations. Students were trained to think beyond theoretical economics and focus on:

- job creation,
- SME development,
- community entrepreneurship,
- local economic empowerment,
- and sustainable livelihoods.

This aspect of the IDS programme was particularly important because many graduates later worked with NGOs, rural banks, microfinance institutions, development projects, and district assemblies.

2. Department of Environmental & Resource Studies

The Department of Environmental & Resource Studies was one of the most technically oriented departments within FIDS. It combined environmental management with development planning and spatial analysis.

The department emphasized:

- Environmental Management
- Natural Resource Management
- Climate and Development
- Sustainable Agriculture
- Environmental Impact Assessment
- Forestry and Wildlife Management
- Water Resource Management
- Biodiversity Conservation
- Land Resource Analysis
- Environmental Policy

What made this department especially advanced for its time was the inclusion of technical and geo-spatial training such as:

- Geographic Information Systems (GIS)
- Remote Sensing

- Cartography
- Surveying
- Spatial Analysis
- Resource Mapping

Historical departmental descriptions from UDS later confirmed that students were trained in “aerial photography, remote sensing and Geographic Information Systems.”

The department prepared students to understand the relationship between:

- the environment,
- human settlements,
- climate,
- agriculture,
- natural resources,
- and sustainable development.

Students were also trained to assess environmental problems and propose practical community-based solutions.

3. Department of Social, Political & Historical Studies

The Department of Social, Political & Historical Studies focused on the governance, social, cultural, and political dimensions of development.

Students studied courses such as:

- Sociology
- Political Science
- Governance and Development
- African Political Systems
- Human Rights and Development
- Public Policy Analysis
- Conflict and Peace Studies
- Leadership and Governance
- Social Change and Modernization
- Contemporary African Issues

This department helped students understand:

- how political systems influence development,
- how governance affects poverty reduction,
- how historical events shape modern societies,
- and how social structures influence community transformation.

The department also emphasized:

- decentralization,
- democracy,
- community participation,
- social justice,
- and public administration.

This interdisciplinary approach made IDS students capable of understanding development not only from an economic perspective but also from social and political perspectives.

4. Department of Planning, Land Economy & Rural Development (DPLERD)

The Department of Planning, Land Economy & Rural Development (DPLERD) focused on physical planning, land administration, rural transformation, and participatory development planning.

Students were introduced to:

- Rural Development Planning
- Land Use Planning
- Regional Planning
- Settlement Planning
- Geographic Information Systems (GIS)
- Rural Livelihood Systems
- Project Planning and Management
- Monitoring and Evaluation
- Community Mobilization
- Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA)

The department emphasized practical community-centered development approaches and trained students to work with:

- district assemblies,
- land administration institutions,
- rural development agencies,
- and planning departments.

The inclusion of planning and land economy made the IDS programme far more comprehensive than many traditional Development Studies programmes in Ghana during that period.

5. Department of Communication Studies

The Department of Communication Studies addressed one of the most overlooked aspects of development — communication.

The department trained students in:

- Development Communication
- Communication for Social Change
- Journalism for Development
- Public Relations
- Media and Society
- Community Media Systems
- Development Reporting
- Advocacy Communication
- Radio Production
- Communication Research

The philosophy behind this department was that development cannot succeed without effective communication and public participation.

Students learned how to:

- communicate development policies,
- educate rural communities,
- conduct advocacy campaigns,
- use media for social transformation,
- and promote participatory development.

This communication-oriented approach gave IDS graduates strong public engagement and advocacy skills that were highly valuable in NGOs, government institutions, and development projects.

The Importance of the Third Trimester Field Practical Programme (TTFPP)

One of the most innovative aspects of the IDS programme was the Third Trimester Field Practical Programme (TTFPP), which exposed students directly to rural communities for practical fieldwork.

Students participated in:

- Participatory Rural Appraisal (PRA)

- Community needs assessments
- Environmental surveys
- Household data collection
- Resource mapping
- Development planning exercises
- Community engagement activities

This practical model helped students connect academic theory with real-life development challenges across Ghana and made the IDS programme one of the most community-oriented programmes in the country.

Recently, using the generative AI platform ChatGPT, I reconstructed portions of the historical course structure of the Environment and Resource Studies specialization under the BA Integrated Development Studies programme at UDS Wa Campus around the 2008/2009 academic year.

Although the reconstructed curriculum generated through AI may not be perfectly identical to the official historical handbook, many of the courses strongly reflect what I personally encountered and observed when I applied for the programme in 2009.

This exercise demonstrated how advanced and interdisciplinary the UDS/FIDS academic structure was during that period. It also highlighted the importance of integrating:

- technical education,
- environmental studies,
- governance,
- entrepreneurship,
- planning,
- communication,
- and field practical training into Development Studies education.

I therefore respectfully propose that the Faculty of Development Studies at Valley View University:

1. Study the historical academic structure of the former FIDS at UDS/UBIDS.
2. Explore academic collaboration opportunities with UBIDS.
3. Review and modernize its Development Studies curriculum.
4. Incorporate more practical and technical components such as GIS, environmental assessment, participatory rural appraisal, and development planning.
5. Introduce stronger community-based field practical programmes similar to the TTFPP model.

Such reforms could help position Valley View University as one of the leading private universities in Ghana offering a more comprehensive and practically oriented Development

Studies programme capable of producing graduates equipped for modern development challenges.

As someone connected to both institutions, I believe academic collaboration between Valley View University and UBIDS would not only strengthen curriculum development but also contribute to national development by producing graduates with stronger practical, analytical, environmental, and community development skills.

Reference Documents

BA. Integrated Development Studies (IDS) – UDS Programme Structure (2008/2009 Academic Year Reconstruction)

[UDS IDS Programme Structure Reconstruction PDF](#)

BA. Integrated Development Studies – Environment and Resource Management Specialization

[Environment and Resource Management Specialization PDF](#)

More information about my work and projects can be found on my website:

[Solomon Yaw Adeklo Official Website](#)

Solomon Yaw Adeklo

Alumnus of Valley View University and former student of the Faculty of Integrated Development Studies, University for Development Studies Wa Campus.